

The 'I Already Sent Money' Recovery Playbook

The Immediate 72-Hour Action Plan

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Read this BEFORE you need it. If money has already moved — start at Hour 0 and don't skip steps.

Hour 0-1: FREEZE EVERYTHING

1. Call your bank or financial institution IMMEDIATELY. Use the number on the back of your card — NOT any number the caller provided. Say exactly:

"I believe I'm the victim of fraud. I need to freeze the transfer and file a claim."

2. Wire transfers: ask to recall/reverse the wire. Banks have a recall window — every minute counts. Your bank files a recall request through the receiving bank (Fedwire system).

3. Gift cards: call the issuer (Visa/Mastercard/American Express gift card support) with the card numbers. Unredeemed balances can sometimes be frozen or refunded.

4. Crypto: transfers are irreversible, but report to the exchange used (Coinbase, etc.) — some can flag the receiving wallet through chain-analysis partners.

5. Zelle / CashApp / Venmo: file a dispute in-app immediately. Then call support and escalate to the fraud team.

Hour 1-24: DOCUMENT AND REPORT

6. Preserve everything: - Call logs and timestamps - The cloned voicemail or audio message (do not delete!) - Text messages - Transaction receipts / confirmation numbers - The exact number that called you

7. Report to the FBI IC3: <https://ic3.gov> — file a complaint with all details. This is required for most bank recovery processes.

8. Report to the FTC: <https://reportfraud.ftc.gov>

9. Report to local police: get a case number — banks often require it before releasing funds.

10. Notify your bank's fraud department IN WRITING (email), so there's a timestamped paper trail.

Day 1-3: ESCALATE AND PROTECT

11. Escalate at the bank: - First agent says no? Ask for the **fraud department**. - Then the **ombudsman / compliance**. - Be polite, persistent, and reference your **IC3 complaint number**.

12. Secure everything else: - Change passwords on all financial accounts - Enable two-factor authentication everywhere - Freeze your credit (Equifax, Experian, TransUnion) - Alert the family group — the scammer may re-target with the same script

13. Talk to a human. This was a crime against you, not a personal failure. The emotional toll is real — tell someone you trust.

⚠ THE SECOND SCAM WARNING

The scammer will likely call again — often pretending to be a “recovery agent,” “refund specialist,” or “FBI liaison” who can get your money back for a fee.

THAT IS A SECOND SCAM. Real recovery is free. Report, don't re-engage. Never pay anyone to recover money.

Recovery Odds (Be Honest With Yourself)

Method	Reported within hours	Reported after 72h
Bank wire	Good odds	Poor
Credit card chargeback	Good odds	Fair
Zelle/Venmo/CashApp	Fair	Poor
Gift cards	Fair (if unredeemed)	Very poor
Crypto	Very poor	Essentially zero

The faster you act, the better your odds. Every hour counts.

The 3 Numbers You Need Right Now

1. **Your bank's fraud line:** _____

2. **Your credit card fraud line:** _____

3. **Local police non-emergency:** _____

Fill these in now, before you need them.

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